

DLBCSCW01 - Collaborative Work

Task 3: Acting Effectively in Collaborations

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Project Overview

This project covers communication, conflict and negotiation within collaborative work. It explores how communication, conflict and negotiation influence group interactions and decision making by analyzing real-life experience. By applying some theories from the course, the presentation evaluates the group responses to challenges faced, responses to the challenges and lessons learned for future collaborations

Communication

- Communication refers to the exchange of information, ideas, emotions and expectations between individuals. It involves making an effort to understand the other person's need and perspective, even when their views differ from yours.

It is the foundation of collaboration, as people must understand one another before they can make decisions or work towards a shared goal

- Miscommunication occurs when people do not fully understand each other's message, intention or needs.
 - A good example of effective communication is a teacher who explains a concept to students and then asks the students to explain it back in their own words, and the students are able to give a good explanation. This goes to show an understanding was achieved
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Communication as a Social Interaction

A social interaction is any exchange between two or more people where they influence, respond to or communicate with one another.

Communication is often explained through “channel theory”: a sender encodes a message, sends it through a channel and a receiver decodes it

Communication does not just involve word, but also tone of voice, facial expression, body language, listening and feedback

Every message communicated contains a content (what is said) and the relationship (how it is said and what it implies)

Effective Communication

Effective communication builds trust, reduces misunderstandings and ensures successful collaboration.

Some factors that contribute to effective communication include:

Active listening

Fully concentrating on and understanding the speaker before responding.

Right context

Communicating in a manner that suits the situation, audience, and environment

Feedback loops

Exchanging responses to clarify and improve understanding.

Empathy

Recognizing and respecting the feelings and perspectives of others.

Mutual understanding

Developing a shared interpretation of information

Timely response

Responding quickly enough to keep communication clear and productive.

Case Study: Planning a Summer Trip

A challenging communication situation occurred when my friend group was planning a summer trip. We needed to agree on the destination, travel dates, budget and accommodation.

The main disagreement was whether we should travel to Spain or France. Some friends preferred Spain because of the beaches and the nightlife, while others preferred France because of the culture, travel connections and cost. We also had different opinions about the type of accommodation, whether a hotel or an Airbnb.

Different opinions made it difficult for the group to agree on one plan. Some messages were not discussed properly and the decision making became slow. This made it harder to choose an option that everyone was comfortable with.

Understanding the Conflict

Conflict arise when interdependent parties believe they have incompatible goals and are preventing each other from achieving their objectives. (Hocker et al., 2022, p. 3)

The situation an interpersonal conflict because although they share the same goal of planning a successful trip, they have different preferences like destination and accommodation. These differences in interest delay the groups decision-making.

The conflict mentioned above involves an **either-or dilemma**, choosing between two options and choosing one means giving up the other; selecting one destination means excluding the other. And since not all preferences could be satisfied, negotiation became necessary to find a solution that was acceptable to all members.

Negotiation

Negotiation plays an important role in conflict resolution, enabling individuals with different interests to work together towards an acceptable decision. Effective negotiation aims at satisfying all parties while maintaining positive relationships.

Instead of arguing over whether Spain or France was a better destination, each member explained the reasons behind their preference such as budget, accommodation and desired activities. This required active listening, which was essential for effective communication, as the group members considered each other's perspectives rather than simply defending their own opinions.

Evaluating the Negotiation Solution

Following the active listening, the group adopted a compromise negotiation approach to reach a solution that was acceptable for everyone. By identifying the main factors behind each preference, we selected a destination while incorporating activities that members were interested in from both Spain and France. Similarly, for accommodation, the group considered factors like cost, comfort and convenience. By adjusting individual preferences, members were able to reach a balanced solution that promoted collaboration rather than competition.

Overall, the group adopted a soft negotiation approach, as members prioritized maintaining relationships and reaching an agreement by making compromises when necessary (Fisher et al., 2011)

Evaluating the Negotiation Solution

The compromise negotiation approach enabled the group to reach a collective decision. However, there were some challenges throughout the process.

Strengths of the solution

- The discussion improved the group's communication by encouraging members to express their needs and listen to alternative opinions.
- Combining preferred activities and considering accommodation factors helped create a travel plan more acceptable to everyone
- The compromise allowed different preferences within the group to be considered rather than prioritizing only one opinion

Limitations of the solution

- Combining aspects from different options may require additional planning and budgeting.
- Some members had to adjust their initial expectation as the final decision could not satisfy every individual preferences.

Personal Reflection

This experience helped me understand my strengths and the areas I need to improve. Some of them include:

Strengths

- Active listening and willingness to consider different viewpoints
- Ability to adapt and find compromises
- Ability to organize information and identify common ground

Areas of improvement

- Being more confident in expressing my ideas
- Manage disagreements early before they escalate
- Strengthen my negotiation skills

Conclusion

Through this experience, I learned that conflict can be a valuable learning opportunity when managed constructively. Through active listening and open communication, I realized that being open to different ideas creates opportunities for better negotiation. Going forward, I plan to apply these skills in both my studies and professional collaborations to support effective teamwork.

This experience also reinforced the idea from the introduction that communication is only effective when a shared understanding is achieved. Similar to the teacher example in the introduction, where understanding is confirmed through students explaining the concept in their own words, our group reached better decisions by listening to and understanding each other's perspectives.

Reference

- Hocker, J. L., Wilmot, W. W., & DiPaola, S. (2022). *Interpersonal Conflict* (11th ed.). McGraw-Hill. <https://studentebookhub.com/wp-content/uploads/2024/preview/9781260836950.pdf>
- Fisher, R., Ury, W., & Patton, B. (2012). *Getting to yes* [electronic resource] : Negotiating an agreement without giving in (third edition, revised edition). Random House Business Boo.

Thank You